

ERIN E.
McCABE



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LIBRARIAN / MAKER



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ErinEMcC.github.io

PROFILE

A cross-disciplinary (often digital) artist combining literary, narrative expression with visual art. My creative practice is curiosity-driven, grounded in the research skills of my work as a librarian. I'm especially interested in de-familiarizing our knowledge systems; archives, datasets, travel guides, information visualizations, instruction manuals, etc.

LIBRARY WORK

Reference Librarian

PA College of Technology 2025- 2026

I provide research support and instruction for students in every domain; Design to Forestry to Aviation Mechanics.

Open Science Liaison

Princeton Plasma Physics Lab 2023 - 2026

I support open science at a national lab. Collaborating w/scientists and librarians, I build visualizations and care for the meta/data and systems that help determine how knowledge circulates, connects, and persists.

Digital Scholarship Library Fellow University of Cincinnati 2018 - 2023

Using text analysis, machine learning, and visualization, I developed digital research projects in cross-disciplinary teams while contributing to the teaching, platforms, and invisible labor that support scholarly and creative inquiry.

EDUCATION

Brown University

2023 - 2025

- MFA Digital & Cross-Disciplinary Literary Arts

Pratt Institute

2014 - 2016

- MLIS Library & Info Sciences
- Certificate in Digital Humanities

Concordia University (Montreal)

2004 - 2008

- Bachelors of Art, French Studies

MATERIAL & DIGITAL TOOLS

- Rug Tufting (machine)
- Sewing & Machine Embroidery
- Laser Cutting
- Python / JavaScript / Arduino
- Information Visualization
- Video

COMMUNITY

- **Pennsylvania Master Naturalist**
Local conservation service work
- **Books through Bars**
Sending books & info resources to incarcerated people
- **NYPL Correctional Service**
Reference by mail to incarcerated patrons



WORK (cont)

Publisher Support Associate JSTOR / ITHAKA 2014 - 2018

I created data reports to support the development of collections and translate patterns of use into insights for over 400 small-scale academic publishers.

Adjunct Reference Librarian Long Island U (Brooklyn) 2017 - 2018

I guided students through a labyrinth of medical research databases and the best principles of their use in academic writing.

TEACHING

D&xD Literary Arts 1

Intro to Digital & Crossdisciplinary Lit Art in the context of other methods-centric movements (Dadaism, OuLiPo, etc.) Workshops, code-assisted writing, & critical making.

D&xD Literary Arts 2

Adv. studio-workshop. Students pursue a sustained theme, blending lit. w/visual & digital methods drawn from avant-garde & contemporary art. Iterative making and artist-led inquiry.

SELECTED PUBLICATIONS & PRESENTATIONS

"Early Identification of Family Medicine Physicians Using Qualitative Admissions Data" with Jackie Knapke, Barbara Tobias, Saundra Reagan, and Hillary Mount. Family Medicine (2022). DOI: [10.22454/FamMed.2023.596964](https://doi.org/10.22454/FamMed.2023.596964)

"Identifying Essential Nonprofits with a Novel NLP Method" with Michael Jones and Rebecca Olson. Nonprofit Management & Leadership (2022). DOI: [10.1002/nml.21532](https://doi.org/10.1002/nml.21532)

"Convergence in Viral Outbreak Research: Using Natural Language Processing to Define Network Bridges in the Bench-Bedside-Population Paradigm" with Margaret V. Powers-Fletcher, Sally Luken, Danny Wu, Philip A. Hagedorn, et al. The Harvard Data Science Review, 3(1) 2021. DOI: [10.1162/99608f92.cc479d52](https://doi.org/10.1162/99608f92.cc479d52)

"Data-Informed Tools for Archaeological Reflexivity: Examining the substance of bone through a meta-analysis of academic texts" with Sarah E. Jackson, Caleigh E. Richissin, and James Jaehoon Lee. Journal of Internet Archaeology, 55 (2020). DOI: [10.11141/ia.55.12](https://doi.org/10.11141/ia.55.12).

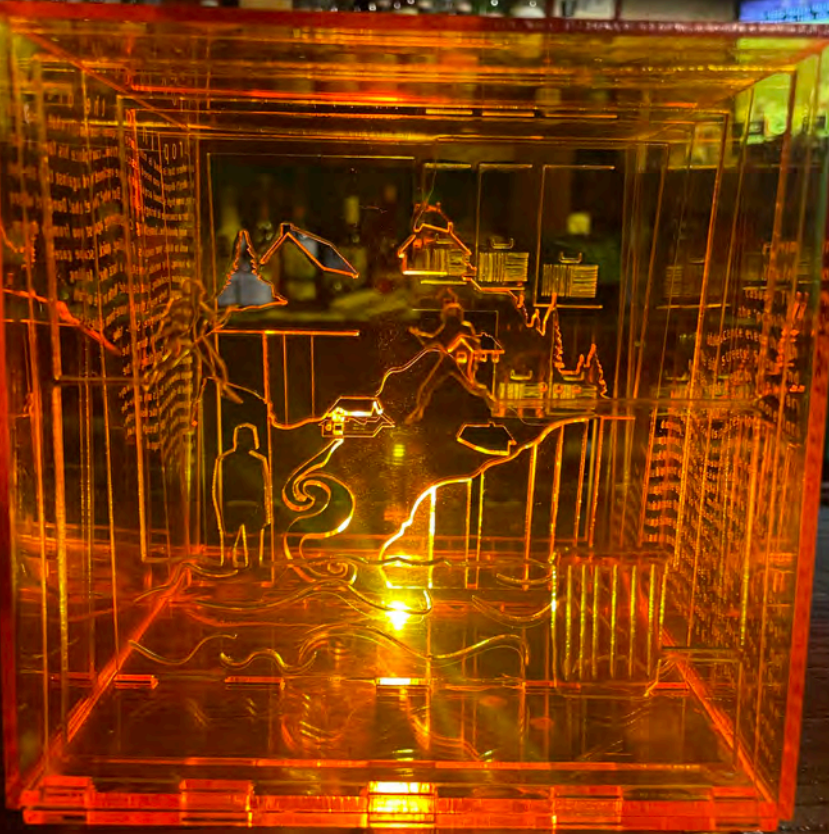
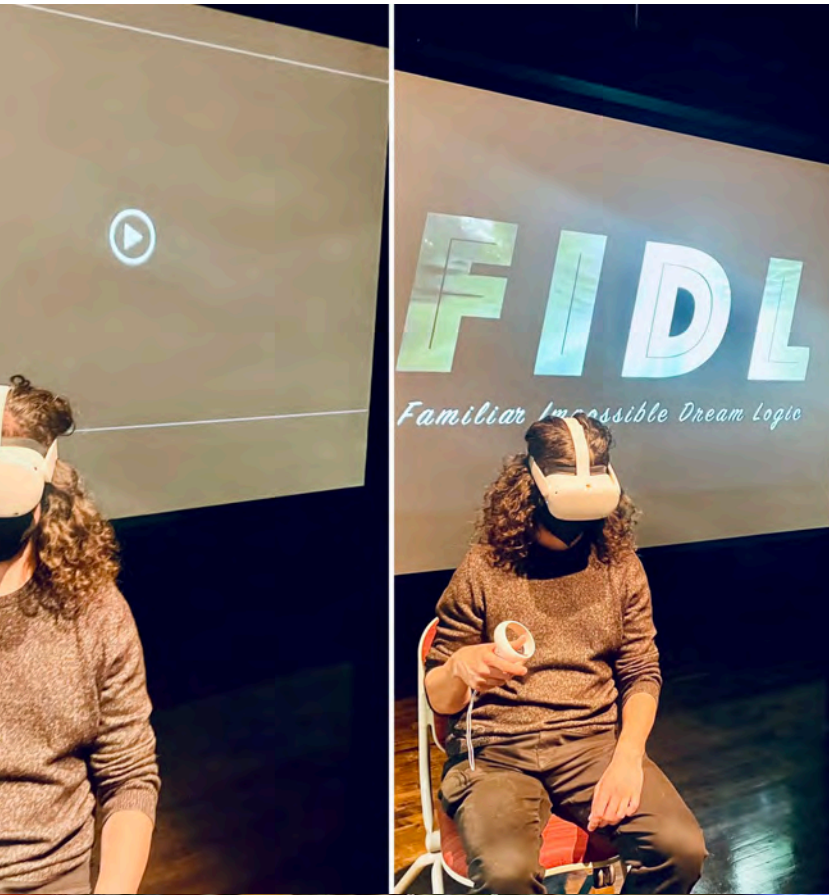
"MFA Thesis Presentation Series" with Tiffany Mi, Lindsey Pannor & Shefali Trivedi at The Brown University Literary Arts Department. Providence, RI. May, 2025.

"Can You Hear Me Major Tom? The US Mass Media Reporting on Exploration of Space." with Aida Ramusovic at The Space Research Institute for Discovery & Exploration (SRIDE) Annual Symposium. Cincinnati, OH. November 2022.

"Doctrinal Implications of Computational Antitrust." Paper Presentation with Felix B. Chang at Computational Antitrust: Exploring Antitrust 3.0 (CodeX - Stanford Center for Legal Informatics). December. 14, 2021. (Additional interview on [Ep. 6 of Stanford's Computational Antitrust Podcast.](#))

Familiar / Impossible

FIDL (*Familiar Impossible Dream Logic*) is a company using AI to generate the ever-elusive, dream-logic. FIDL offers participants the opportunity to curate, collect, & archive their very own dreams. Several controversies arise causing the company to close. Instead - it goes underground.



THE INSTALLATION CONTAINS SEVERAL PARTS

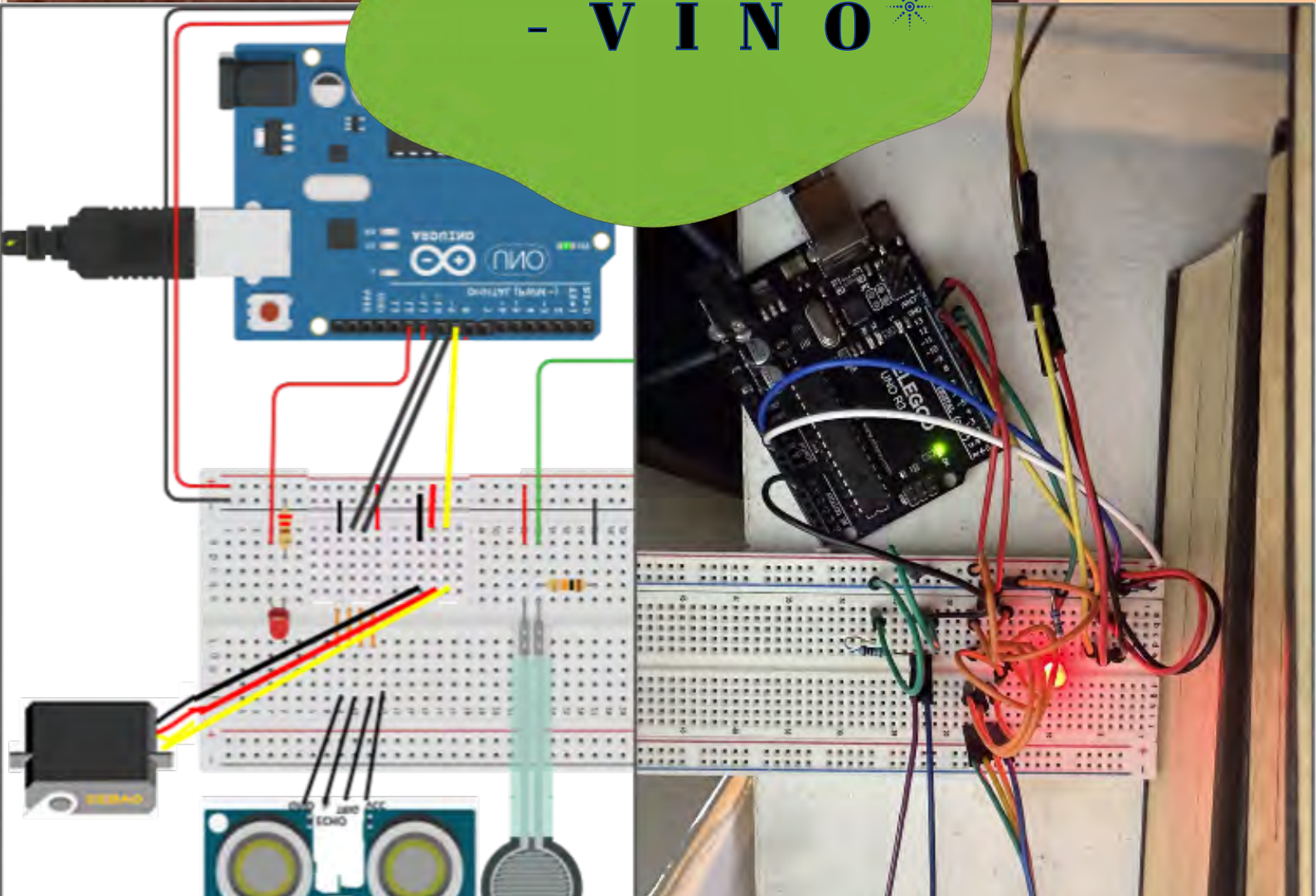
Video takes viewers along a FIDLr's use of the dream-machine where a nightmare is collected. Viewed through an AR headset (left, top) and can be simultaneously cast to a larger screen (video stills, above).

Following the video, the resulting archival unit is revealed (left). Seemingly produced by the machine as its record format, the layered laser-cut acrylic shadow box is etched with language from the dream and lit from below.

Watch the FIDL video here:
erinemcc.github.io/giraffe-fidl.html



G O L D - - V I N O ✨



If One Day You Want to Read, *If on a Winter's Night a Traveler*

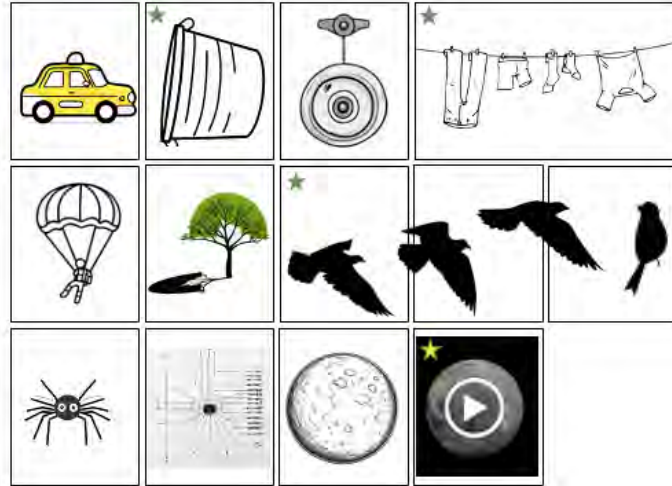
IODYWTR is a Rube Goldberg style chain reaction contraption inspired by - and with the end goal of - reading Italo Calvino's, *If on a Winter's Night a Traveler*. The contraption spans/combines spatial reality and animation (or daily tasks and daydreaming). A person activates it via pressure sensor, moving the contraption from material space, into animation, then back out again.

MEDIUM

Mechanical installation (physical objects w/Arduino) + Animated video

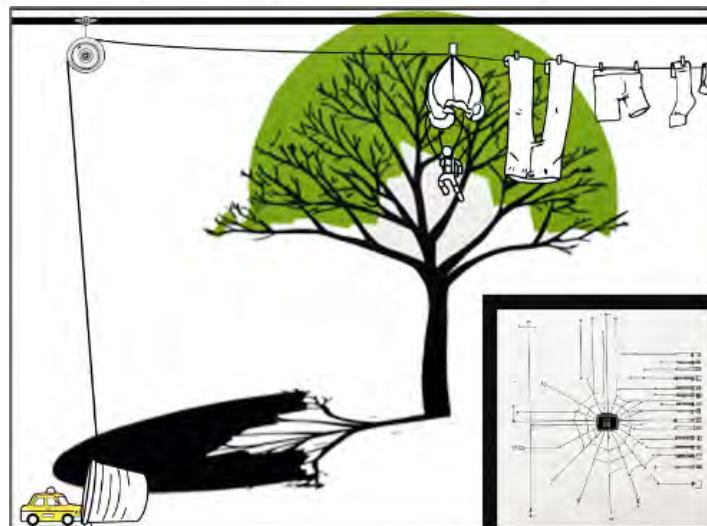
RUNTIME

2 minutes



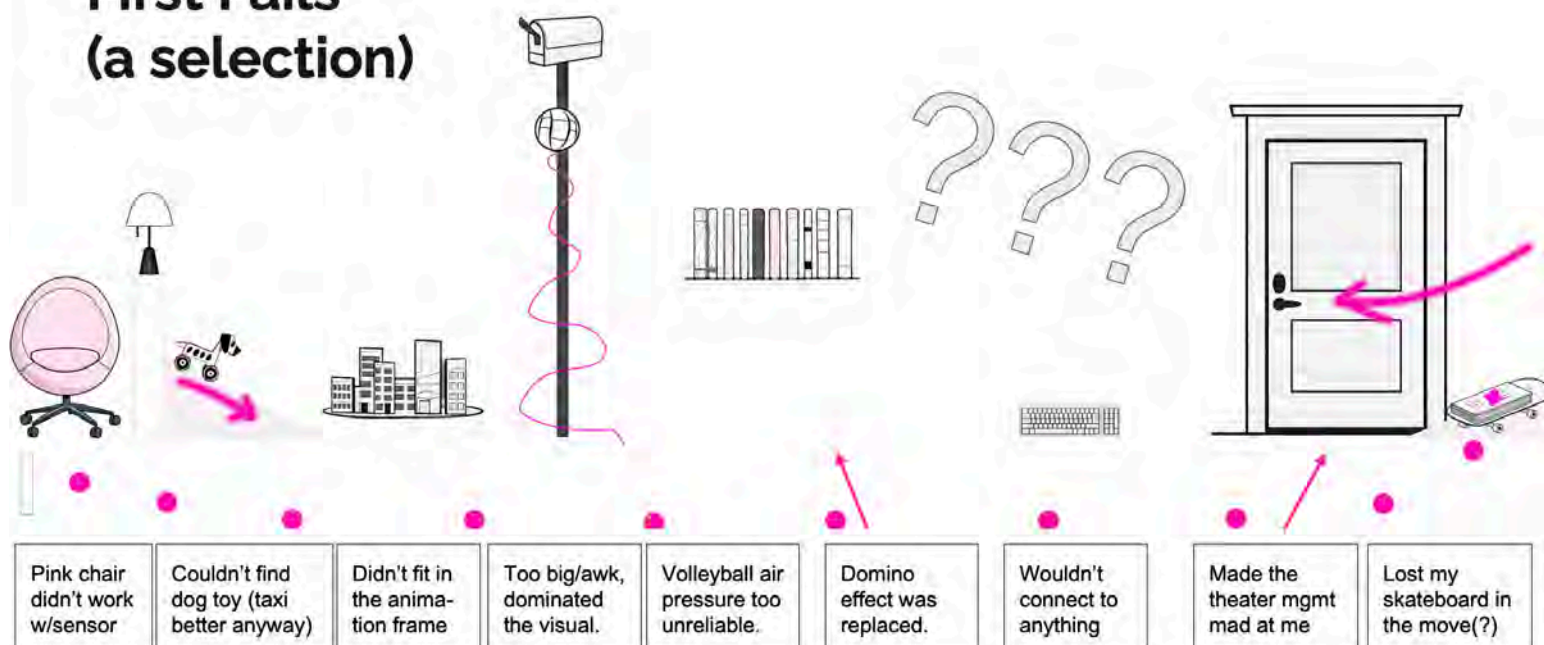
Animation Assets

★ Stock images (adobe)
★ NASA public domain (edited)



Animation Still

First Fails (a selection)



The Snell Field Guide

This is a circus story, a disappearing story, a based-on-a-true-story story told through collaged interfaces - more specifically, the kinds of interfaces that interact with our reality in some manner (e.g. Shazam for song recognition or various identification apps for plants, stars, etc). This interface construction is connected to the more recent notion of “second-screen content” (engaging with a secondary screen while watching something else).

The first chapter (below) invites a user to a specific location where, using their phone as interface, they are directed to move through the space along with the story.

The documentation accompanying the video project is styled as a vintage field guide, in a nod to historic information sources/structures, as well as the specific timeframe of the baseline circus story (1876).



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ANNA/STASIA GETS ON BOARD.

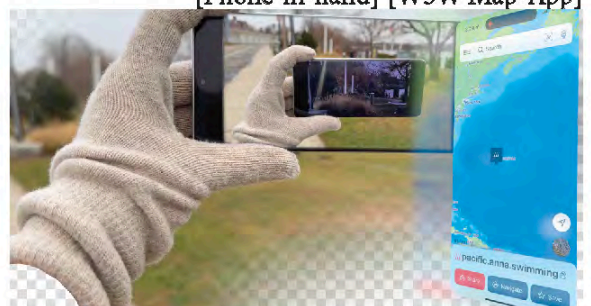
If you're in the living room, reading a book, the living room tends to disappear. But you are walking at the edge of the water. Move your screen up to the Boat-house sign. Keep it in your vision. Follow the camera east, to your left. Take this sidewalk to the park entrance then turn right onto the path.

[Phone-in-hand]



The river leads to Narragan-sett Bay, then on to the Atlantic Ocean. To get to the Pacific in 1876 - where

[Phone-in-hand] [W3W Map-App]





Rug made for the oral
'storytelling'
performance of *The
Snell Field Guide*



D O G S T A R



After finding an archive of someone's family videos posted online, I was surprised at how much they began to feel like my own memories.

Using them as source material, I began blending in new media and - in the tradition of the Language Poets - the fragmented memories from the days before I had reality fixed (and I thought I was related to the dog).

Watch the Dog Star video here: erinemcc.github.io/dog-star.html



Aunt Rita

When winter started to thaw and it should have been a pleasant, hopeful sort of morning, all 535 members of the 124th United States Congress suffered the exact same nightmare, and each woke up with the same dream-jolt feeling of falling. After solidifying their place on Earth (recognizing their Icecap Blue walls, verifying bedmates, and wiggling fingers over where a horn might be), each one muttered to no one in particular, “Fuck, that was so real”. Not one among them disclosed the nightmare, instead marinating on its psychological impact independently. This left their spouses wondering about (14%), grateful for (33%), or oblivious to (52.9%) their distracted breakfast silences. Every representative trudged through the morning with an especially furrowed brow, maybe undeservedly snapping at an aide, but altogether shaking off the nightmare’s echoes by just after lunch.

The nightmare returned that night though. And the next. And the one following that. After a month, Congress had collectively lost 21.1 inches of tooth but only the D.C. area dentists noticed the strange increase in bruxism, shrugging it off as a stress oddity and sighing “politics as usual”. Everyone suffered silently, convinced they’d gone insane and were at risk of losing their position.

The nightmare was this:

Face down in dirt, you are so broken by thirst you can’t move. Instead of the insignificant, human body you’ve learned to lug, there’s an unrecognizable weight. You’re covered in tobacco-brown fur and that too seems to ache from dehydration, every vibration tender. A drop of rain lands on your flat, broad snout, but disappears in dense tufts before it can cool your hide. For the first time in years, you pray and you mean it. Sounds of thunder turn out to be a train and you return sharply to atheism, cursing every inch of steel. Your dream-logic eyes follow another raindrop underground—an entire universe where the raindrop travels wildly through roots, a whirling dervish among joyful bugs, fungi, pockets of air. Unable to tolerate the sight any longer, you shift back to the surface for a blade to suckle, but you’ve thrashed yourself a grassless wallow. Buckthorns advance like infantry and a ferocious itch to drag your frame across their bark crashes in. This is banishment. You hear the rain sneering as clearly as a bullhorn. Indignation stirs your weight and your hindquarters almost lock, then collapse. Your horn crunches against a rock in the soil sending reverberations through your skull and causing snot to drip from your cavernous nostril. Carrying an impossible weight, an inflamed cerebrum, and an intense disdain for every other living thing, the ground can no longer support you. Your trench crumbles and you fall...

Night after night, 535 representatives become powerless, nightmare bison exiled from rain, roots, trees. Night after night, snot mats their fur and their skulls glisten red, then white, as they plummet.

On day thirty-something of this torment, Aunt Rita presented herself to Congress, requesting USDA funding so Midwestern farms could mimic prairies for preservation and agricultural benefits. She held no delusions. Her thoughts alternated between the conviction that she was there to “speak truth to power”, and the strong desire that someone open a goddamn window somewhere.

They all looked so unbelievably thirsty for her testimony. She shifted her weight under their unblinking gaze, then scraped some composure from an index card, continuing, “75% of a prairie’s biomass is underground.” A tremor passed through the impossibly captive audience.

“W-We’ve eviscerated the topsoil,” she stumbled on. “Intricate microorganisms struggle to clump together, diminishing space for rain.”

“Where does the rain go?”

Aunt Rita is thrown by the childlike poetry. She can’t tell which member it came from, so she directs her response to the group. “Heavy rain causes floods. Farmers need to be convinced — subsidized — for strips of prairie we can bring back to their land.”

“What about the bison?”

Again, it seems that the question came from no one in particular, or rather, from everyone in general, and Aunt Rita’s vision pulses with a momentary vertigo, failing to locate the asker.

“Only 30 or so bison remain in Illinois”, she answers, “but we can take on some of their labor — be the bison.”

Her Prairie Society friends had warned her against waxing poetic (Don’t bother trying to speak to their souls — they don’t have any!). She bites her lip, damming off any further impromptu lyricism. But no one interrupts, scoffs, or challenges the fiscal viability.

Aunt Rita soon surpasses Fauci in her number of Late Night appearances. At Halloween, the internet gushes over little girls in her iconic safari hat above oversized glasses, linen button downs, and mud-caked white sneakers. The now-famous “Prairie Photo” is taken, her olive and khaki appearing holy-white at the center of Congress’ blue-gray uniforms. In it, Aunt Rita has just pressed her thumb into a milkweed plant, and the photo shows her, arm outstretched, letting the seeds float into the wind like a magical, prairie benediction. The caption reads:

Aunt Rita with members of the congressional subcommittee known as “The Bison”.

Aunt Rita is part of a cycle of stories depicting women in the outdoors, caring for nature and being altered by it.

I wanted to create a story in the tradition of Fabulist literature. Fabulist literary works make for great oral storytelling - a practice I adore. To that end, if you want to close your eyes and be read to instead of reading, the audio version is available online here: erinemcc.github.io/aunt-rita.html



Find the Hidden Objects

Magic

Whisper Network Poem

Caesar Cipher

Asemic Script

Easter Eggs

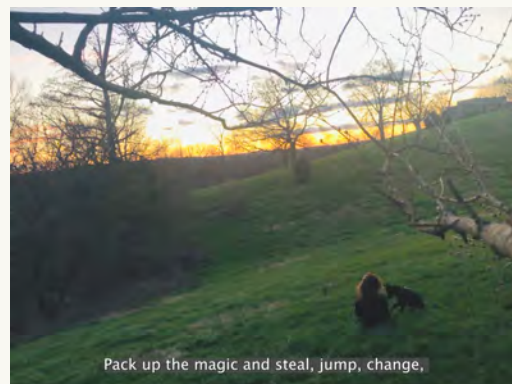
Something that's none of our business

Impossibilities

3 Secrets

2 Lies

+ a Steganography clue



This still video piece is based on the **Collaborative Poetry Experiment (CoPE)** - an expressive writing project created by myself & narrative medicine (NM) facilitator, Dani Clark. CoPE combines NM principles with machine poetry generation. Participants develop a writing practice, then collaborate with 'the machine' (my algorithm), generating poems from their own language to derive personal insight and foster creativity in the everyday.

Read more about CoPE and watch the video here: erinemcc.github.io/cope.html